

55 to 64 is no longer working. If present trends continue, only one in two American men in that age group will be in the labor force in two decades. The bureau reports that more younger men are retiring as well, although not in such high numbers.

Are the young retirees happy in their new lives? The Bureau of Labor Statistics isn't telling. The bureau measures income, net worth, and numbers of new jobs. Ask them to check on happiness, pride, dignity, and the like, and they get bogged down in methodology.

I, however, have no such hangups. I simply go out and ask retirees whether they're happy with their lives. Over the past three years I've talked with hundreds of young retirees, men and women in their 40s, 50s, and early 60s. And I've found that many of them don't like their retirement lives one bit.

The problem, in a word, is boredom. Unhappy retirees long for "something to do," an "office to go to," or "a way to keep busy." They feel stale and restless. I can understand why. On a typical day they watch TV and, for real fun, go to a brokerage office. I suppose they try to decide whether the stock quotation screen is more or less exciting than, say, *Perry Mason* reruns.

So it's possible to hate retirement. But I've also met retirees who love their retired lives. The difference seems to be almost wholly one of attitude. Happy retirees believe they retired to *do* something rather than to *stop* doing something. They view retirement as one of life's phases, like childhood, adolescence, going to school, working, raising a family, and getting cable TV installed. Retirement can be better or worse than the phases that preceded it, depending on what one makes of it.

Happy retirees lead active, programmed lives. They learn new basic skills, in activities that have many facets. They know that hobbies don't quite cut it. It's fun to play golf, garden, and knit. But when they do those things all day every day, they get restless. Happy retirees insist on meatier pur-